

other track and field athletes in India don't come from that sort of background. And while someone like Arjanvir had been preparing for the NCAA admission process from the time he was in school, for most Indian athletes currently in the system, the idea of applying to a college in the USA came a lot further along in their career.

Pradeep is one of the latter. "I grew up in a home where I didn't have money to even buy a pair of shoes. I had no clue that something like the NCAA system even existed," says Pradeep, who was already running against senior athletes and won gold at the 2023 National Games before a coach put the thought of competing in the USA in his mind.

Unsure of how the application process worked, he approached someone who had a better understanding of things. For the past two years now, Tejaswin and his wife **Siddhi Hiray (right)**, herself a national-level athlete and a graduate of the University of Loughborough, have been working with Indian athletes in order to help them manage the recruitment process better — directly coordinating with coaches in the USA.

"The fact that I got a sports scholarship was a bit of a surprise to me. But when Siddhi met me, she had this idea where she felt we needed to give other kids the kind of opportunity that I got. Since the time we started, we have been able to send five kids on a full scholarship to the US," he says.

While Tejaswin and Siddhi are filling an important niche in the system, there's increasing interest for coaches in the USA to directly look out for talent in India. "International recruitment in track and field was a pretty big thing even 10 years ago, but we were predominantly looking at Europe and a little bit in Africa and the Caribbean. But over the last few years, it's been expanding dramatically. NCAA recruiting is really getting into Asia now, which would have been unheard of 10 years ago. I've felt for a long time that India was the next big resource for athletic

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Indian track and field athletes currently in the NCAA



Pradeep Senthilkumar
University of Nebraska

Arjanvir Singh
Wagner College

Sharvari Parulekar
University of Louisville

Selva Prabhu
Kansas State University

Madhvendra Singh
Eastern Washington University

Krishna Jayashankar
University of Nevada Las Vegas

Lokesh Sathyanathan
Tarleton State University

Nidhi Singh
Midwestern State University

Prithviraj Chougule
University of Mary

Poorna Raorane -
University of Memphis

Mimansa Dahiya
University of South Florida

Nirmit Dahiya
Texas A&M- Kingsville

Aishwarya Bharadwaj
Tarleton State University

Adithya Hari
University of Massachusetts

Pavana Nagaraj
San Diego State University

Akshana
Kennesaw State University

Ruthika Saravanan
Charleston Southern University